Telling New Caregivers About Your Wife: Three Mistakes Almost Every Family Makes

How each one shows up, why it's so easy to do, and the habit to put in its place.

You've explained how she takes her tea to three different people this week. Almost every family ends up here, by the same three routes. None of them is a failing, and each has a simple habit that takes its place.

1 Counting on the family to repeat every detail

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE You explain the tea to the person doing the paperwork. Your daughter explains it again to the caregiver on the evening visit. By Thursday there's a new face, and it starts over.

WHY IT HAPPENS Telling people is the natural thing to do, and while you're standing there it works. But you can't be there every hour, and what's said aloud stays with the person who heard it. The Family Caregiver Alliance notes that when a staff member you like and trust leaves, it can be hard for you and your loved one to adjust. [1]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Put the handful of things that matter most on one short page, find out who on the new team will receive it, and ask them to confirm they have it. Keep talking with the people who care for her as well. The page means you no longer have to be the only copy.

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2 Letting familiar routines get lost in the move

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE The first day is forms, signatures and a medication list. Her mornings never come up, because there's no box for them and you meant to mention it later.

WHY IT HAPPENS An admission or a first visit is built around the chart, and everyone is busy, you included. Her routines feel too small to raise next to the medical questions. They aren't: writing about nursing homes, the National Consumer Voice calls introducing your loved one to the staff one of the most important things you can do. [2]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Before the first day, ask her which routines matter most to her through this change. “What does a good day look like for you?” is one way in. Write those few down first: how the morning starts, her meals, the evening. Bring the page with you on day one. [3]

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3 Writing down what the family wants instead of what she wants

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE The page says she enjoys group activities, because you'd like her to have company. Ask her, and she'd tell you she'd rather have the crossword and the door closed.

WHY IT HAPPENS You know her well, so filling in her answers feels like saving her the trouble. AARP's family caregiving guide notes that when families put off talking about values and preferences, decisions may be driven by assumptions, and the National Consumer Voice reminds families of nursing home residents that what their loved one wants may be different from what they think is best. [4] [2]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Ask her, and use her words. Mark the lines you filled in yourself and anything she hasn't confirmed. Then read the page back to her, where she's able, before anyone else sees it. If you and she see something differently, write down both and say which is whose.

The habit under all three

Her words, on one short page, with someone you can name.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't tell you what belongs on her page, which routines the new team can keep, or what she would want if she can't say. It names three habits, the same three the Family Care Roadmap sees at this step.

Ready for the next step?

You know which three habits to change. The care interview gives the new ones somewhere to go: it asks about her preferences across every part of the day, alongside her care needs and the support around her, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The points about staff changes, introducing her to the staff, the good-day question and assumptions come from the sources below. The Consumer Voice fact sheet is about nursing homes. The three mistakes are the Family Care Roadmap's own.

1. Family Caregiver Alliance, Residential Care Options: Caregiving Doesn't End When Your Loved One Moves
2. National Consumer Voice for Quality Long-Term Care, Family Involvement in Nursing Homes (fact sheet)
3. The Conversation Project (Institute for Healthcare Improvement) and Ariadne Labs, What Matters to Me: A Workbook for Better Health Care
4. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families